

IMPACT.

CONVERSION

FREE PLAYBOOK · D2C ECOMMERCE

The 7 Conversion Killers of D2C Ecommerce Stores

A field-tested playbook for store owners who want faster lifts without guesswork. Symptoms to spot, fast fixes to ship, and a score that tells you where to focus first.

Symptoms to spot

Fast fixes

Score yourself at the end

Jono Matla

Founder, Impact Conversion

impactconversion.com

How to use this playbook

1 Skim the 7 killers and mark where you are weakest

Each killer opens with symptoms. If you nod more than once, you likely have the issue. Killers 1 to 6 are stacked with quick wins you can ship this week. Killer 7 is the most important one in the document, and we put it last so you arrive with momentum.

2 Implement the fast fixes

Start with the ones you can ship this week. Most killers have at least one fix that needs a copy change, not a rebuild.

3 Score yourself at the end

Seven killers, zero to two points each. If you want, send me your score at jono@impactconversion.com and I will map the fastest 30-day lift plan.

WHO THIS IS FOR

D2C ecommerce and digital product businesses doing **1,000+ orders a month or \$1M+ a year in online revenue**. That is the volume where A/B testing reads become reliable. If you are below that, the fixes still apply: use the low-traffic path in killer 7 so you do not stall.

Why these seven: after years of running research-led testing programs, the same patterns show up on almost every audit. None of them are exotic. All of them are expensive. Fix the ones that apply to you and you will capture revenue you have already paid to acquire.

01 Weak value proposition (and not being consistent)

Have you ever seen a great ad, been almost sold on the product from the ad alone, then clicked through to a page that does not live up to the hype? It actively reduced your probability of purchasing. You could be making the same mistake.

THE THREE VERSIONS OF THIS MISTAKE

The landing page doesn't match the ad

Testing different angles and claims in ads is fine. But if the landing page does not back up the claim that earned the click, conversion suffers. Symptoms: high bounce, low scroll below the fold, high exits from the pricing section, and survey answers showing confusion about the offer.

The page doesn't match the awareness stage

Problem-aware visitors get feature lists. Solution-aware visitors cannot see why you are different. Product-aware visitors cannot find the risk removal. The pattern: engagement with weak progression to checkout, plus feedback like "not sure if this solves my situation" and "what's the refund?"

There is no unique value proposition at all

If someone lands on your site, can they answer "who is this for?" and "why should I care?" in five seconds? Is your offer actually different, or do five other companies claim the same thing?

The car analogy: everyone knows what a car is. They know the problem (too far to walk) and the solution (a vehicle). The advertiser's job is to make them product aware: sell the specific car, in their price range, with the features they are in market for. Nobody selling cars re-explains walking. Match your message to what your buyer already knows.

A QUICK TEST

Walk someone new through your landing page and ask: **What's in it for me? Why should I choose you over the alternative? Why is that a good thing? Can you prove it?** If they cannot answer those, you have a value proposition problem.

THE FIX

1

Restore ad-to-page scent

When someone clicks an ad, they arrive with a specific promise in mind, and the landing page should feel like the same conversation. Echo the ad's key phrase in the H1 or first subhead line, keep the same angle and benefit, and repeat any incentive you offered. Running multiple angles? Swap the headline, proof, and CTA based on campaign parameters so every visitor sees the page that matches the promise they clicked.

2

Tune the hero to the awareness stage

- **Problem-aware** visitors need to see you understand the problem and the cost of doing nothing before you promise the transformation.
- **Solution-aware** visitors want your unique mechanism and why it beats the alternatives.
- **Product-aware** visitors are deciding now: surface price, guarantee, outcomes, and make the CTA immediate.
- **Unaware** visitors need the big-idea hook first, then the problem, then the outcome.

3

Clarify the UVP and prove it

State a single-sentence promise that answers who it is for, the outcome, the timeframe, and the most common objection. Use it as your H1 and repeat it in the title tag. Name your mechanism: the inputs that make you different, the process, and the measurable output versus alternatives. Quantify benefits wherever you legitimately can.

Then hold the **evidence adjacency rule**: every important claim sits next to proof within one scroll, on desktop and mobile. A testimonial, a stat, a recognisable logo, or a quick demo.

VALIDATION CHECKS

5-second test

Can a fresh user say who it is for and what they get?

Logo-swap test

Would the page read the same with a competitor's logo on it?

Scent check

Does the headline repeat the ad's key promise and phrasing?

Ship this week: echo your best ad's exact phrase in the H1 · answer your number one objection in the subhead · run the 5-second test on three people who have never seen the site.

02 The trust and authority gap

If your website does not earn people's trust, you might as well throw away half your customers. The factors that move trust run much wider than testimonials:

- Does the site look visually trustworthy, like a professional entity?
- Is there a real founder or team behind it, with a track record?
- Are your guarantees specific and strong, or weak, or missing?

- Do your testimonials back up the outcome you claim to deliver?
- Do you have third-party reviews? Can a buyer find your about and contact pages easily?
- Are recognisable payment methods visible near the CTA?

HOW TO SPOT IT

Low conversion rates

Obviously. But trust is the cause more often than most teams think.

Bounce patterns that hunt for trust

Design-related distrust bounces fast. Claim-related distrust engages, then searches the site for proof, then leaves.

Pre-sale inquiries

"Is this legit?", "Can I see case studies?", "Do you have a guarantee?" If support keeps hearing these, the page is not surfacing enough trust.

THE FIX

Testimonials, case studies, reviews

Use text and video, place them next to products and CTAs rather than at the bottom of the page, and keep them fresh.

Recognisable logos

Partner, client, or press logos at strategic points: homepage, landing pages, just before checkout. Only logos your audience will recognise.

Strong guarantees

Specific and actionable beats vague: "30-day no-questions-asked refund," stated prominently in plain language.

Hard data behind claims

Attribute numbers to sources, and visualise the key ones so they get seen.

Ship this week: guarantee within sight of every buy button · one real founder or customer photo replacing stock · review count and rating next to the CTA · kill any countdown that is not real. When you add proof: timestamp it, include denominators, skip the stock headshots.

03 Above-the-fold fog

The term comes from newspapers: folded on the stand, only the top half showed, so publishers put their best work above the fold. On a landing page it is everything visible before scrolling, and 100% of the traffic that lands sees it. No other part of the page has that reach.

HOW TO SPOT IT

The 5-second test fails

Visitors cannot tell who it is for, what they get, or why it is different within five seconds.

No action, no scroll

Click maps show more attention on the navigation and logo than the primary CTA. Scroll depth is thin. Cold traffic wants detail before "Buy now" and cannot find it.

Weak or misplaced proof

Decorative stock imagery, no testimonial or stat near the fold, and low video play rates. Quick scrolls, quick exits.

THE FIX: WHAT BELONGS ABOVE THE FOLD

1

Your headline

The clear value proposition from killer 2. Who it is for and the outcome they get.

2

A subheadline that earns the claim

Expand on the headline and explain why you can do what you just claimed.

3

A primary call to action

Make the next step obvious. One action, not three.

4

Credibility indicators

At least one trust element visible without scrolling: proof, testimonial, or guarantee.

5

Key visuals

Obvious product photos or short video that reinforce the offer. Show the thing.

5-second test protocol: show the hero to ten fresh users and ask: who is this for, what do I get, what should I do next? Pass if at least seven of ten answer all three without scrolling.

Ship this week: add one proof element above the fold · make the CTA the most visually obvious thing on the page · cut the header nav links on paid landing pages.

04 Friction: speed, forms, payments, logins

HOW TO SPOT IT

Slow pages

Load speed is the most common form of friction, and the most measurable. Mobile cold traffic feels it worst.

Abandonment and rage clicks

Cart abandonment at specific steps, rage clicks in session recordings, and people failing to find things through navigation or search.

Support tickets for simple things

Track support requests per 1,000 purchases. Rising tickets for basic tasks means the site is making people work.

THE FIX

1 No login before checkout

I have personally run tests where removing forced login before checkout was worth \$300k+ a year. If you need accounts, create them after payment, not before.

2 Fix Core Web Vitals where it counts

Run PageSpeed Insights on your highest-traffic templates first. Compress media, defer non-critical scripts. Targets: LCP 2.5s, CLS 0.1, INP 200ms.

3 Map the jobs your visitors came to do

Figure out whether the navigation gets people to their goal fast. Test menu structures against direct category routing, and check how many people actually use the nav and what for.

4 Checkout field audit

Ten or fewer visible fields, optional fields clearly marked, autofill enabled, correct mobile keyboards, inline validation as people type.

5 Geo-matched payments

Mirror the top payment methods for each market you sell into, show prices in the buyer's currency, and keep recognisable processor marks near the CTA.

Ship this week: turn on guest checkout · enable Apple Pay, Google Pay, and PayPal · collapse the coupon field behind a link.

05 Leaving money on the table post-purchase

The moment someone buys is when trust and motivation peak. If you do not extend that momentum, you cap lifetime value and make every new-customer dollar work harder than it has to.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Weak repeat-purchase rate

90-day cohorts repurchase under 10% and the 12-month repeat rate never clears 20%.

Low average order value

Items per order hovers at 1.0 and order-bump attach sits in the low single digits.

Flat revenue per visitor

Traffic climbs, add-to-cart looks fine, but dollars per session will not budge. Nothing is compounding.

Stalled upsells

Post-purchase offers see under 5% take, and support grumbles about pushy extras. The offer is mismatched or badly timed.

Quick diagnostics: pull 90, 180, and 365-day repurchase rates, bump and upsell attach rates, and tag refund themes.

THE FIX

1 Smart order bumps at checkout

A tightly related add-on priced at 15 to 30% of the main product, framed as completing the kit. A 20% attach on a \$49 bump across 1,000 monthly orders is roughly \$9.8k a month.

2 One-click post-purchase upsells

Immediately after payment, one yes-or-no offer with no card re-entry. Tight hook, benefit bullets, one social-proof tile. A 5 to 10% take is a good baseline; one client's post-purchase offer hit 26%.

3 48-hour activation sprint

A short email or SMS sequence that gets the product used: a clear next step, a getting-started nudge, a quick survey. Usage drives the second order.

4 Review and referral at the win moment

Trigger the ask at the first win with the product, not three minutes after checkout. Happy scores get the referral ask, low scores route to support.

Ship this week: add one order bump priced at 15 to 30% of your hero product · move the review-request email to land after delivery, not after checkout.

06 No experimentation or measurement discipline

Testing is how you stop guessing. Without it, shiny redesigns and "best practices" become expensive coin flips, and variance can make a bad change look good for a day before it sinks performance for weeks.

But messy testing is not much better. Calling tests early creates false positives, and underpowered experiments create confidence without truth, so you scale the wrong ideas and stall. Proper testing de-risks build time, finds the cheapest path to lift, and compounds learning.

Quick definitions:

- **MDE:** the smallest lift worth caring about
- **Power (aim for ~80%):** whether your traffic can detect that lift
- **Statistical significance:** the reason you do not call winners early
- **SRM:** a broken traffic split. Pause and fix before reading anything.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Redesigns that fall flat

You ship a full new page and watch conversion fall once the novelty wears off, with no way to isolate which change caused it.

A win rate that makes no sense

You test, but wins are rare and inconsistent, because hypotheses are not grounded in research.

Uplifts that never reach revenue

Occasional green dashboards, but the revenue line barely moves: wrong metric, sample too small, or the change does not survive across devices and regions.

THE FIX

1 Check you have the volume, then test properly

Around 1,000 orders a month is where A/B test reads become reliable. Use a simple protocol: research, hypothesis, sample-size calculation, run, post-test analysis, log. And read impact across the full funnel (visit, add to cart, checkout, purchase), not a single click metric.

2 Prioritise ruthlessly

Score every idea by expected revenue impact, how confident the evidence makes you, and the effort to ship. Sort, and run the top items within capacity. Fewer tests, done right, raise both win rate and revenue.

COMMON PITFALLS

Underpowered tests

Calculate the minimum detectable effect first, then wait for enough sample. Hope is not a sample size.

Novelty effects

Compare early and late cohorts. Do not ship day-one wins.

Broken splits

Check the traffic split matches what you set. If it is off, pause and fix before reading results.

Uneven device and geo mix

Segment before you ship. A win that only holds on desktop in one country is not a win.

Confounded changes

On lower traffic, isolate variables. A variant with five changes cannot tell you which one worked.

WHERE TO START TESTING

- High-friction areas of your landing pages: around the CTA and key decision points
- The elements above the fold (killer 4): every visitor sees them
- The homepage hero: nail the value proposition from killer 2
- Navigation: can you get the visitor to done faster?
- And every fix in this playbook: each one is a hypothesis worth testing rather than assuming

IF YOU HAVE LOW TRAFFIC

Bigger swings, not micro tweaks

Offer packaging, pricing, guarantees, and hero messaging. Use directional metrics (revenue per visitor, add-to-cart, AOV) rather than chasing significance.

Qualitative-heavy loops

Interviews, user tests, on-site polls. Smoke tests for demand: soft launches, waitlists, pre-sale pages with clear refund policies.

Longer windows, sequential ships

Extend test windows or batch releases, and watch cohort trends rather than day-to-day numbers.

Log everything

Document learnings in a simple log so decisions compound, win or lose. Twelve months in, the log is the asset.

Ship this week: start the test log, one row per change you ship · pick one primary metric and write it down · book a weekly 30-minute decision slot.

07 You don't know why people buy (or don't)

We saved the most important killer for last. Every quick win in killers 1 to 6 works better once this one is in place, but it takes real effort, so bank the fast fixes first. I know how it is: shipping products, designing pages, testing new ads is the exciting work. Customer research sounds boring, and for the most part it is. But if you are writing headlines, objection-handling copy, or ads without understanding what actually causes your customer to convert, you are stabbing in the dark.

HOW TO SPOT IT

Your page isn't converting, and you're unsure why

Good business is providing a solution to a problem someone has. If you do not understand the problem, or what motivates them to buy your solution, your business is running on an assumption. And the moment you started marketing the company, you crossed a line you cannot go back on: you can never be your target market again.

Opinion-based shipping

"It annoys me, so it must annoy customers" is spending money on an assumption. You see your website every day in ways your customers never do. Of course you are tired of the page you have seen a thousand times. It might be working, and you are changing it because you are bored of it.

Made-up messaging

If your headlines and product names come from a brainstorm in a board room, your messaging reflects what you believe is important. It will keep missing the actual motivations, anxieties, triggers, and desired outcomes of your buyers.

THE FIX: THREE WAYS TO START, IN ORDER

1 Talk to your customers

Email your list and ask to jump on a call. Add an incentive, like a voucher giveaway, and aim for at least 5 to 10 conversations. Ask:

- Who they are, and why they were interested in the first place
- How they heard about you, and how hard it was to find a solution to their problem
- Which competitors they considered, and what made them choose you instead
- What almost stopped them from buying
- Their biggest fear or concern with buying from you, and what got them over it
- Whether the product met their expectations, and why

Then run the same questions as a survey to your list for volume. Do the calls first: they tell you which questions the survey should ask.

2

On-site surveys

Same idea, but in the moment, which gets you different answers. Use an on-site survey tool and ask at key points in the journey:

- **On purchase success:** "What was the one thing that almost stopped you from purchasing today?" and, separately, "What convinced you to buy from us today?"
- **On landing pages** (desktop on exit intent, mobile around average engagement time): "What appeals to you most about our products?", "What, if anything, holds you back from purchasing?", "What could we do to make your decision easier?"
- **On the homepage:** "What was the purpose of your visit today?", "Were you able to complete it?", and the follow-up "why not?" when the answer is no.

Run one survey on the purchase journey at a time, for at least a week or about 100 valid responses per key segment.

3

User testing, if budget allows

Ten tests in total, five mobile and five desktop, on your main funnel. Define clear goals, qualify hard (100% target market, never purchased from you), focus on tasks before opinions, give minimal guidance, ask them to think aloud, and keep each session to 20 or 30 minutes on one or two core flows.

WHAT TO DO WITH THE RESEARCH

Compile everything into one document and categorise it: **motivations, values, frictions, anxieties, objections**. Compare converters and non-converters. You are answering two questions: "what convinced customers to buy?" and "what almost stopped them?"

From there, theorise ways to amplify what convinces people and counter what stops them. Put the ideas in a spreadsheet and rank them by expected conversion impact against implementation difficulty. That ranked list is your testing roadmap for the next quarter.

A caution on AI analysis: the easy path is dumping the data into an AI tool and asking for insight. It works as a first pass, but the tools still make things up. Check the quotes are real before you base a landing page on them.

Ship this week: launch the one-question post-purchase survey today: "What was the one thing that almost stopped you from buying?" An hour to set up, and it keeps paying for years.

SCORE YOURSELF

Where does your store stand?

Zero, one, or two points per killer. 0 = big problem, no system in place. 1 = some effort, inconsistent or partial. 2 = dialled: documented, measured, consistent.

01 · Value proposition clarity and consistency

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

02 · Trust and authority

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

03 · Above-the-fold clarity

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

04 · Frictionless speed and checkout

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

05 · Post-purchase LTV engine

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

06 · Experimentation discipline

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

07 · Know why people buy (and don't)

☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2

READ YOUR TOTAL (OUT OF 14)

0 to 6

You are leaking revenue everywhere. The good news: the first few fixes will be the cheapest revenue you ever add.

7 to 10

The foundations are there. A focused 30-day push on your two weakest killers usually pays for itself.

11 to 14

You are close. Tighten process and speed; the gains now come from testing discipline, not obvious fixes.

READY TO TURN YOUR SCORE INTO REVENUE?

Want us to find your leaks for you?

Book a free 15-minute intro call. We will look at your funnel together and tell you straight whether a CRO program is worth running on your traffic. No pitch deck, no sales script. Send your score from the previous page and you will get a straight answer on where to focus first.

Book a 15-min intro call →

The guarantee on every 90-day sprint: you see a revenue uplift, or we refund the final 50% of the sprint fee. The full terms, in plain English, are at impactconversion.com/guarantee.

Prefer email? jono@impactconversion.com